

THE PEACOCK

Pavo



SIZE RANKING 44

BRIGHTEST STAR
Peacock (α) 1.9

GENITIVE Pavonis

ABBREVIATION Pav

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
July–September

FULLY VISIBLE
15°–90°S



Pavo is one of the far-southern constellations that were introduced at the end of the 16th century by the Dutch navigator–astronomers Pieter Dirkszoon Keyser and Frederick de Houtman (see p.416). It represents the

peacock of southeast Asia, which the Dutch explorers encountered on their travels. In more recent times, its brightest star, 2nd-magnitude Alpha (α) Pavonis, was given the name Peacock.

In Greek mythology, the peacock was the sacred bird of Hera, wife of Zeus, who traveled through the air in a chariot drawn by these birds. It was Hera who placed the markings on the tail of the peacock after an episode involving Zeus and one of his illicit loves, Io. Although Zeus had disguised Io as a white cow, Hera suspected something was amiss and set the 100-eyed Argus to keep watch on the heifer. Her husband retaliated by sending his son Hermes to release Io. In order to overcome Argus, Hermes told him tales and played music on his reed pipe until the watchman's eyes closed one by one. When Argus was finally asleep, Hermes chopped off his

head and set Io free. In his memory, Hera then placed the eyes of Argus on the peacock's tail.

The constellation Pavo is to be found on the edge of the Milky Way south of Sagittarius and next to another exotic bird, the toucan (the constellation Tucana).

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Kappa (κ) Pavonis is one of the brighter Cepheid variables. Its fluctuations, between magnitudes 3.9 and 4.8 every 9.1 days, can be followed with the naked eye.

Xi (ξ) Pavonis is a double star with components of unequal brightness—4th and 8th magnitudes. The fainter star is difficult to identify with the smallest-aperture telescopes because its brighter neighbor overwhelms it.

NGC 6752 is one of the largest and brightest globular clusters in the sky. It is just at the limit of naked-eye

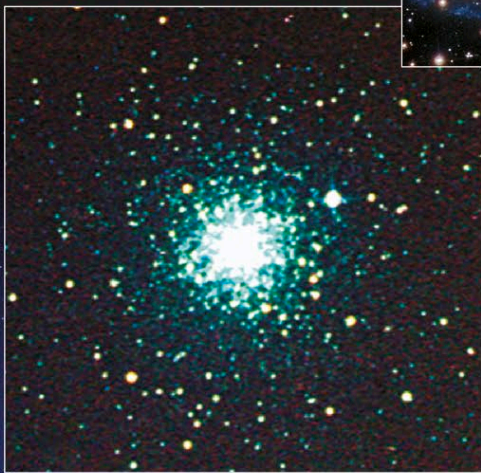
visibility but readily located through binoculars. It covers half the apparent width of a full moon. A telescope with an aperture of 3 in (75 mm) or more will resolve its brightest individual stars.

The large spiral galaxy NGC 6744 is presented virtually face-on to the Earth. It is visible as an elliptical haze in a telescope of small to moderate aperture. NGC 6744 lies about 30 million light-years away.



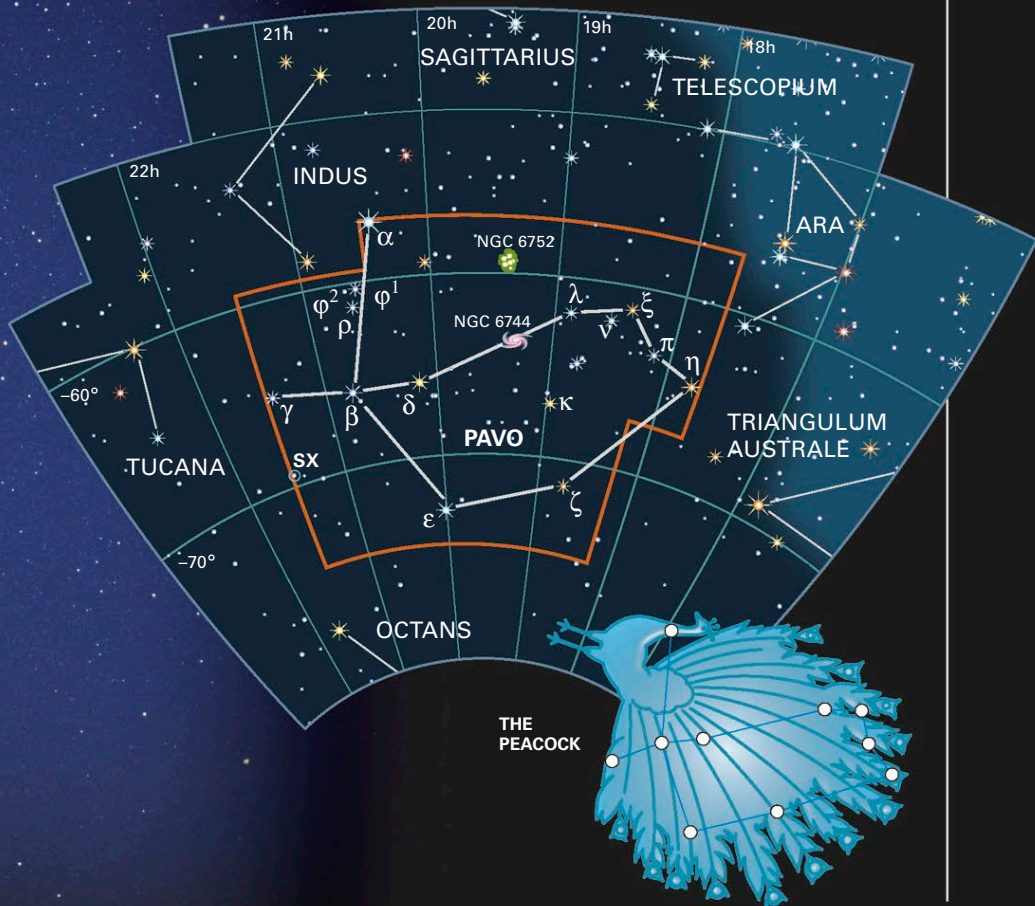
NGC 6744 ✨

This beautiful barred spiral galaxy in Pavo is detectable through a small telescope. The Milky Way might appear like this when viewed from the outside.



NGC 6752 ✨

The fine globular cluster NGC 6752 remains little known because of its far-southern declination. The bright star seen above right of it in this image is a foreground object in our galaxy.



CELESTIAL DISPLAY

The constellation Pavo, the Peacock, is depicted fanning its tail across the southern skies, in imitation of a real-life peacock when attracting a mate.